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Junk We Never Said Thank You For

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[Two long-time friends, Amelia *and* Collin *sit around a backyard campfire, reminiscing on their childhood adventures before Collin's wedding the following morning.* Amelia *is already seated.* Collin *walks over*.]

COLLIN: I figured everybody would be asleep by now.
AMELIA: *(shrugs)* I'm not tired really. The fire's warm. It's kind of peaceful out here.
COLLIN: You mind?
AMELIA: You? Never. *(she gestures for him to join her)*
COLLIN: Ohh, sometimes you mind me.
AMELIA: *(teasing)* Only when you're an idiot, and that's only like sixty percent of the time.
COLLIN: Gee, thanks. I've always hoped for a best friend who called me an idiot.
AMELIA: Honesty equals love, so at least you know I love you.
COLLIN: Comforting. Thanks.
AMELIA: Anytime. *(it's quiet for a couple of beats)* What are you doing up anyway?
COLLIN: Couldn't sleep, I guess.
AMELIA: Nervous for your big day tomorrow?
COLLIN: *(laughs)* I'm not sure nervous is the right word. I was just…thinking.
AMELIA: Yeah? What about?
COLLIN: I guess just that…we've been through a lot together.
AMELIA: You and Julie?
COLLIN: No, dummy. You and me. *We've* been through a lot together.
AMELIA: You're thinking about me on the night before your wedding? Definitely not a good sign, man.
COLLIN: *(rolls his eyes)* No, I just mean, you're my best friend, Mill. You've done a lot for me.
AMELIA: More than my share, I'd say.
COLLIN: Probably. I did stuff for you too, right?
AMELIA: I think you gave me a high five once.
COLLIN: Oh shut up. I let you crash on my couch for like a month in college.
AMELIA: Yeah. Do you remember the blind date you went on while I was crashing on your couch?
COLLIN: *(winces)* Oof. Yeah. Vividly.

[FLASHBACK to college. Collin comes home from a date. Amelia is on the couch in his apartment watching TV.]

COLLIN: Never again, Millie!

AMELIA: *(shuts off the TV with remote)* It could not have been that bad. What'd she do, bite?
COLLIN: Why do I never learn? Blind dates are the bane of my existence!
AMELIA: So she did bite?
COLLIN: *(rolls his eyes)* I didn't get close enough to risk it.
AMELIA: You're so dramatic. I'm sure she was a nice girl. Who even set you up?
COLLIN: Milo.
AMELIA: Yikes. Okay, maybe not. *Why* would you let *Milo* set you up on a date? Do you *want* a venereal disease?
COLLIN: This one was *bad* bad, Mill. Like - you remember Loony Lisa from 8th grade science camp?
AMELIA: Oh yeah! She sent you all of those letters drenched in perfume and that weird doll with her face on it.
COLLIN: Worse than that.
AMELIA: No way. It could *not* have been worse than Loony Lisa.
COLLIN: No? Allow me to demonstrate. Come here. You be me.
[Collin sets up two chairs and gestures to one. Amelia reluctantly sits down].
COLLIN: Okay - we're at dinner. You start the conversation. Just be normal. Be…me.
AMELIA: You want me to pretend you and normal are synonymous?
COLLIN: Can you not be a sarcastic pain in my neck for ninety seconds, please?
AMELIA: Right. Yes. This isn't weird at all. My apologies. Proceed.
COLLIN: Thank you. Now, we're at dinner. Just introduce yourself. Ask me about me.
AMELIA: Okay. *[she becomes Collin - slouches back in her chair, shifts her face]*
COLLIN: What are you doing? What is *that*?
AMELIA: I'm being you.
COLLIN: I don't *sit* like that. I don't *look* like that.
AMELIA: Well in lieu of plastic surgery, Collin, I can't *wear* your face!
COLLIN: No - I don't….make that face. You look half annoyed and half constipated.
AMELIA: Fine. I'm going to buy you a mirror because my impressions are always spot-on. But fine. *(clears her throat and lowers her voice)* Hi. Nice to meet you. I'm Collin.
COLLIN: *(shifts his posture to act like his date)* Milo says you're a *phenomenal* kisser.
AMELIA: *(breaking character)* That was *not* her opening line!
COLLIN: Yes! It was. Now focus, it gets worse.
AMELIA: Wait, does Milo *know* if you're a phenomenal kisser?
COLLIN: Millie, focus!
AMELIA: So, he does?
COLLIN: Amelia!
AMELIA: Right, sorry. *(as Collin)* So, tell me about yourself. What's your name? What do you do? Are you going to school?
COLLIN: *(as his date)* My name's Gwen. I *am* currently a student, but I don't think the whole student thing is really fulfilling my life plan.

AMELIA: *(breaks character again)* This is so weird. Why can't you just *tell me* about your date like we're *normal* people??
COLLIN: Okay, fine. So she tells me that she's planning on quitting school because she'd like to be a full time *mother*.
AMELIA: So she has kids?
COLLIN: No! She doesn't have kids. She would like to consider having *my* kids.
AMELIA: No.
COLLIN: She asked me about my sperm count.
AMELIA: Shut up.
COLLIN: Not a joke.
AMELIA: What did you say??
COLLIN: Well obviously at that point I knew the date was *over*.
AMELIA: But what did you say?
COLLIN: I told her I didn't think we'd be a good fit for a relationship.
AMELIA: Uh huh.
COLLIN: But then she said she didn't necessarily need a relationship.
AMELIA: Yikes. Milo *is* setting you up for a venereal disease.
COLLIN: So then she tells me her car is right down the block. If I were interested…
AMELIA: Which you weren't.
COLLIN: I mean she was pretty hot.
(There's a knock on the door).
AMELIA: You *didn't.*
COLLIN: No. I'm just saying - she was hot.
(There's another knock at the door).
COLLIN: Did you order a pizza or something?
AMELIA: Nope.
COLLIN: Invite someone over?
AMELIA: Maybe your date followed you home.
COLLIN: It can't be. Right?
AMELIA: Goofy Gwen. Here to procreate. Right on cue.
COLLIN: You answer the door.
AMELIA: No way!
(The knocking persists).
COLLIN: Millie, please!
AMELIA: What am I supposed to *say*?
COLLIN: Tell her I'm not home!
AMELIA: You're eight feet from the door!
COLLIN: I'll hide! Pretend you're my angry girlfriend or something.
(Still knocking)
AMELIA: You *owe* me, Collin.

COLLIN: Yes! I absolutely owe you!
AMELIA: Buying my dinner every time we go out for the rest of your life!
COLLIN: Fine. Okay. Just answer the door!
[Amelia opens the door. Collin hides behind the furniture. We don't hear Gwen, but we hear Amelia's responses to her which become more and more hysterical. Collin winces and panics in reaction to every comment made.]
AMELIA: Hello? .... I'm Debbie. Who are *you*? … NO, *I'm* Collin's girlfriend! Who are *you*? … He did *what*? … That *cheater*! I'm the mother of his unborn *child*! … We're getting *married*! … If he comes home tonight I'm going to *light his car on fire! ... [Amelia slams the door shut and immediately stops the hysterics].* Crazy enough for ya?
COLLIN: A little too good. Light my car on fire?
AMELIA: Crazy responds to crazy.
COLLIN: She probably won't be back right?

[PRESENT: Amelia is laughing. Collin is shaking his head, horrified.]

COLLIN: She absolutely *did* come back.
AMELIA: Yeah, real glad I was done squatting at your pace by that point.
COLLIN: She set my couch pillows on fire.
AMELIA: You let her *inside* your apartment.
COLLIN: *Milo* let her inside my apartment.
AMELIA: It's a miracle you're still friends with him.
COLLIN: See what I mean though? You've been there for all of my crazy stuff, Mill.
AMELIA: Goofy Gwen was an exceptionally crazy one.
COLLIN: You remember that night we climbed the water tower?
AMELIA: *(nods)* Yeah you almost wet yourself before we got to the top.
COLLIN: I don't like heights!
AMELIA: Didn't Milo dare you?
COLLIN: He bet me I couldn't drop a penny from the top and hit him.
AMELIA: He was right. You couldn't.
COLLIN: I might have been able to if I wasn't shaking my tail off.

[FLASHBACK to junior year of high school. Collin and Amelia are climbing the side of the water tower. Collin is above, moving very slowly. Amelia is below.]
AMELIA: Could you pick up the pace?
COLLIN: *(squeaky and nervous)* How far of a drop do you think this is?
AMELIA: From here? I don't know, like fifty feet?
COLLIN: It seems higher than fifty feet!
AMELIA: Collin, we still have like 100 feet to go!
COLLIN: What do you think happens to a body that falls 150 feet?

AMELIA: I think it *dies*, which is what's going to happen to you if you don't pick up the pace!
COLLIN: Don't rush me!
AMELIA: This was *your* idea!
COLLIN: I wasn't serious! Milo was the one who was serious!
AMELIA: Then why doesn't *Milo* climb up here?
COLLIN: How high do you think we are now?
AMELIA: 52 feet because you've taken a singular step since the last time you asked!
COLLIN: *(breathing heavily)* This was not a responsible decision.
AMELIA: Let's just get to the top, and you can freak out up there. If you freak out here, you'll take me out with you!
COLLIN: Okay. Okay. Breathe.
AMELIA: I *am* breathing. You start climbing!
[They finish the climb to the top. Collin is shaking, maybe also hyperventilating. Amelia is calm.]
COLLIN: *(with his eyes shut)* How far down is it?
AMELIA: We've been over this.
COLLIN: I can't look.
AMELIA: It's actually kind of awesome.
COLLIN: *(peeks one eye open, then the other, looks around them - still nervous but also impressed with the view)* Okay. This *is* kind of awesome.
AMELIA: *(points)* I can see my house from here.
COLLIN: *(points in a slightly different direction)* Mine too.
AMELIA: Okay. Get your penny. Prove your point. *(Collin digs in his pockets and comes out with a coin. He holds it out.)* That's a nickel.
COLLIN: I have this or a dime, and this is a larger projectile!
AMELIA: You bet a penny. We climbed 150 feet into the air, and you don't *have* a penny??
COLLIN: Like Milo will notice he got hit with a nickel.
AMELIA: Like you'll even *hit* Milo with the nickel.
COLLIN: Oh, yea of little faith.
(Collin puts the nickel back into his pocket, steps to the edge and grips the railing. He looks around, seems pretty comfortable. Then he looks down. He is instantly ***uncomfortable*** *- he starts to sway, closes his eyes, opens them again, backs up, squats down - still holding tight to the railing).*
AMELIA: Collin?
COLLIN: A drop like this would *definitely* kill me.
AMELIA: Yeah. Good thing you're launching a coin and not your *body.*
COLLIN: I think I'm gonna' throw up.
AMELIA: Are you kidding me? It took us an *hour* to climb up here!
COLLIN: I can't do it. You do it.
AMELIA: Fine. I'll do it. Give me the nickel.
COLLIN: *(stand up - eyes shut tight - holds his arms out as his sides)* Take it out of my pocket.

AMELIA: I'm not *taking it out of your pocket!* Just hand me the nickel!
COLLIN: I can't move. I'll plummet to my death.
AMELIA: You *climbed* up here. We have to climb *down*.
COLLIN: *(risks a look down)* No! Nope! Not happening!
AMELIA: WHAT?
COLLIN: It's fine. I'm okay. This isn't the worst place to spend the rest of my life. I'll just stay here.
AMELIA: How did I not know you were afraid of heights. How did *you* not know you were afraid of heights?? Come on - let's just climb down. I'll go first, okay?
COLLIN: Not a chance. This is my home now. Call my mom; tell her I loved her.
AMELIA: *(pulls out her cell phone)* Oh for the love of God.
COLLIN: Are you really calling my mom?
AMELIA: No, dummy. I'm calling the fire department to get your scared little kitten butt down from this tree.

[PRESENT: Both of them are laughing.]

COLLIN: Definitely not my proudest moment.
AMELIA: Yeah, but it makes for a good story. Nice little preview of my wedding speech.
COLLIN: You're not telling that story in your speech tomorrow.
AMELIA: Live in suspense, buddy.
COLLIN: Can't you tell some story where I was like strong and heroic and not peeing my pants in fear? Make me look a little bit cool.
AMELIA: Unfortunately, you've gotta' be cool to look cool.
COLLIN: Sometimes I'm cool.
AMELIA: Give me one example.
COLLIN: What about the time I *heroically* took you to prom at the last minute?
AMELIA: My date got mono.
COLLIN: And I, very *coolly*, stepped in to save the day.
AMELIA: That's not heroic. That's common decency.
COLLIN: I'd rather be remembered as decent than as a big chicken.
AMELIA: I'll see what I can do for you.
COLLIN: Come on - are you gonna' tell any story that makes me look cool?
AMELIA: I don't know if cool is the right word - but, yeah…maybe…

[FLASHBACK: Amelia's father's funeral. She is crying on the church steps. Collin comes out and sits next to her.]

COLLIN: Man, it's hot in there. *(loosens his tie)* Why is it common practice to make a funeral an oven? Everybody's already in black layers, and you're gonna' roast 'em alive? It's never made sense to me.
AMELIA: I'm fine, Collin.
COLLIN: I know.
AMELIA: I don't need the comedy routine, okay? I'm fine.
COLLIN: I know.
AMELIA: You can go back inside.
COLLIN: I'm good right here.
AMELIA: I just needed some air.
COLLIN: Okay.
AMELIA: It's not that I can't handle it. I'm fine. I can do it, okay? I'm not running away from it. I just…I just…
COLLIN: Needed some air.
AMELIA: Yeah.
COLLIN: Okay. You need some air. We'll sit in the air.
AMELIA: You don't have to sit with me.
COLLIN: So you mentioned.
AMELIA: I just need to be alone for a minute.
COLLIN: That's fine. I'll be alone with you.
AMELIA: I don't need you.
COLLIN: No. You don't.
AMELIA: I don't need anybody. I'm fine. All by myself.
COLLIN: Yes you are.
AMELIA: Then why are you still sitting here?
COLLIN: Because I love you, Mill. Because this day sucks. Because your dad died. Because you have been the strong one for as long as I can remember, and you shouldn't have to be that today. *(she opens her mouth to protest)* It doesn't matter whether you can. You *can*. But I love you, and I'm your best friend, and you don't have to be the strong one today. You let me do it.
AMELIA: I don't know *how*.
COLLIN: *(wraps an arm around her)* Right now you just sit on these steps with me, and you breathe.
AMELIA: *(leans into him)* I feel like I *can't* breathe. I hate this. It's not fair. This day, this whole dying thing, it's not *fair*.
COLLIN: No. It isn't. It sucks.
AMELIA: It *really* sucks. *(she sobs into his shoulder for a time)*
COLLIN: I've got you, Milie. I'm right here.
AMELIA: *(collects herself, takes a deep breath)* How am I gonna' go back in there?
COLLIN: Through the doors. Down the aisle.
AMELIA: Yeah, but everybody saw me freak out in there, and I'm supposed to be--

COLLIN: You're not supposed to be anything today. All your supposed-to-bes are on me today. So you're gonna' take a breath, you're gonna' hold my hand, and we're gonna' walk back in there together. Whenever you're ready.
AMELIA: I'm ready.
COLLIN: You sure? It really is an oven in there.
(He offers his hand; she takes it).

[PRESENT: Amelia is somber, she's been crying but not heavily. She wipes her eyes, smiles at Collin.]
AMELIA: That was the coolest you've ever been for me.
COLLIN: *(scoffs)* That wasn't cool. That was…I don't know…I didn't think about it, really. You were hurting. I wanted to make it easier.
AMELIA: Yeah. It takes effortlessness to be cool. That wasn't effort. It was just you.
COLLIN: And that was cool?
AMELIA: That was definitely cool.
COLLIN: I'm gonna' repeat back to you what you said, so you know: "It was just *you.* That was definitely cool." You think I'm cool. You said it.
AMELIA: I take it back.
COLLIN: You can't take it back; you said it!
AMELIA: If I had known it would go to your ego like this, I would have kept it to myself.
COLLIN: But you *do* think I'm cool.
AMELIA: You're a headache.
COLLIN: A *cool* headache. A soft sea breeze. A damp washcloth to the forehead.
AMELIA: *(mocking his tone)* A brain freeze.
COLLIN: Okay, fine, I'm done.
AMELIA: Thank you.
COLLIN: Hey, Mill?
AMELIA: Yeah?
COLLIN: Thanks. For all that junk. For the junk I never say thank you for.
AMELIA: That's the point of a friend, dummy. You don't have to say thank you for the junk. The junk is what makes us friends. If there isn't any junk, it's just the surface layer, just the easy stuff.
COLLIN: You're easy stuff.
AMELIA: And clearly we've capped our serious conversation limit for the evening.
COLLIN: Yeah, ten minutes, and I'm tapped. *(taps his head)* It's all one-liners, and punch lines in here now.
AMELIA: Junk?
COLLIN: Less important junk.

[He winks at her. They share a look. Freeze.]